

4K TVs

All hype? Or some substance? Read on...

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Having launched in 2012, 4K TVs didn't take the world by storm. And why would it? The monstrous things cost an awful lot. Even in those parts of the world where large format TVs sell for dirt cheap, these 4K TVs cost an arm. But things have changed in the last few years with the 4K standard becoming more and more mainstream and they're all the more affordable now. Let's see what's on the horizon at the moment.



4K UHD is still finding its feet

For one, 4K at a respectable frame rate requires a lot of bandwidth. Now this depends on the content to a large extent, slow paced TV shows and movies will look fine on 4K at 30 Hz while action scenes and live-action sports look crappy even on 100 Hz. HDMI 1.4 which is used in almost every DTH set top box, DVD or Blu-Ray player and even on 4K TVs is limited to 4K at 30 Hz. So unless the HDMI 2.0 standard, which was finalised last September, is widely accepted, the content side of 4K isn't looking great. Even HDMI 2.0 is limited to 60Hz for 4K so sports will still be an eyesore till the next HDMI standard comes

into the picture. This is why the demo videos in TV stores are all running really slow. It's a simple relation between resolution and framerate. So a high frame rate should be accompanied by a high refresh rate.

Let's say you're not a stickler for picture quality and a little blur every now and then is fine. You'd still require 4K content to watch, right? DTH providers have only announced 4K streams with no official launch date mentioned at the time of writing this article. So now you have to settle for either a media player or a streaming service. If you were to buy a media player then ensure it has HDMI 2.0 and that might pose some problems since some of these media players only work with TVs from the same manufacturer. If you're thinking of streaming content then Netflix or Amazon are great options (starting this October) and you'll need a good VPN and a steady bandwidth of at least 15 Mbps to sustain a buffer-free playback.

The sad truth is that 4K technology is yet to mature and manufacturers are already pushing out 5K and 8K displays. So it's best to wait it out for another year but if you want to try out the benefits of 4K straight away then you can buy a 4K media player and have it downsampled to Full HD resolution so you can experience a better picture quality, similar to NVIDIA's DSR. 

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